

SCRUM LEADERSHIP SERIES

Scrum Mastering III: Learning Objectives

Thirteen modules. Each module maps directly to one chapter of Scrum Mastering III: Organizational Improvement. These objectives are used to demonstrate understanding for the Recognized Scrum Master 3 credential.

The domain of practice and a Practice Partner are part of the learning.

These objectives are not met by recognizing the language or repeating an accepted explanation. The book and the course must be coupled with the learner's domain of practice, where actual conditions, constraints, and evidence give the objectives meaning.

Every learner works with a Practice Partner: another learner, a practitioner within the learner's domain, or a 3Back Expert Echo. For each significant objective, learners explain it in their own words, connect it to actual work, question one another's accounts, test assumptions and competing explanations, and identify the evidence that would support or challenge their conclusions.

The Practice Partner makes the learner's reasoning visible and correctable. The facilitator provides guidance and calibration, but cannot supply the learner's domain experience or establish professional capability for them. Capability develops through repeated judgment, action, and evidence in the work.

Learning approach: This document applies the learning model described in How 3Back Approaches Learning, 3Back, September 2026.

3back.com/papers/how-3back-approaches-learning

MODULE 01

It's the People, Stupid!

- 1.1 Evaluate Scrum as behaviors people use to solve hard problems, not as a recipe.
- 1.2 Use the Scrum Manifesto as the test of whether a group is still doing Scrum.
- 1.3 Distinguish the Production Game from the Improvement Game.
- 1.4 Contrast Team Product Owner, Product Champion, and Business Owner.
- 1.5 Judge whether a Team is self-organized, self-contained, and value-driven.
- 1.6 Evaluate Psychological Safety and Working Agreements as conditions for those behaviors.

MODULE 02

Cynefin and Scrum

- 2.1 Classify a live problem as Simple, Complicated, Complex, or Chaotic.
- 2.2 Explain why Scrum belongs in the Complex domain rather than the Simple one.
- 2.3 Diagnose when Product Ownership work has slid into Chaotic decision-space.
- 2.4 Use Scrum's Development Guardrails to keep Complex work from becoming Chaotic.
- 2.5 Compare Tuckman maturity phases with Cynefin domains as this book maps them.
- 2.6 Recommend a probe-sense-respond move instead of a plan built for Complicated work.

MODULE 03

Lean, Agile, and Scrum

- 3.1 Evaluate a value stream against the Perfection Loop's five core Lean concepts.
- 3.2 Identify DOWNTIME wastes in the learner's own delivery path.
- 3.3 Apply the Seven Lean Principles to an Organizational improvement choice.
- 3.4 Judge whether a Team is pulling work or pushing work.
- 3.5 Recommend which waste to attack first without pretending the rest is gone.

MODULE 04

Facilitating Decision-Making

- 4.1 Design a decision process on the Diamond of Participation from Introduction through Closure.
- 4.2 Hold a group in the Groan Zone long enough for a real option to appear.
- 4.3 Evaluate who should facilitate an Organizational decision and who owns the outcome.
- 4.4 Use the two-axis effort plot to decide where a group should spend its energy.
- 4.5 Facilitate an Organizational decision without stealing ownership of the result.

MODULE 05

Coaching

- 5.1 Select among the book's nine coaching stances as the Team's need shifts.
- 5.2 Move between Hands-On Expert, Teacher, Coach, and Partner without freezing in one.
- 5.3 Use Reflective Observer and Truth-teller to name what the Team will not say.
- 5.4 Evaluate when Counselor or Mentor is the wrong stance for a Scrum Master.
- 5.5 Treat personality tools in this book as communication data, not as labels to manage people.
- 5.6 Design a coaching approach for a Team inside the learner's organization.

MODULE 06

Team Effectiveness

- 6.1 Evaluate a group on the Katzenbach-Smith J-Model from Working Group to Real Team.
- 6.2 Diagnose Team failure using the Lencioni Trust Pyramid.
- 6.3 Judge whether mutual accountability is present or only individual performance.
- 6.4 Design Working Agreements that would move a Potential Team toward Real Team.
- 6.5 Interpret Scrum Master accountability for Team effectiveness in Organizational terms.
- 6.6 Assess whether a named Scrum Team is a Working Group wearing Scrum language.

MODULE 07

Technical Skills and Capabilities

- 7.1 Use Scrum's three Guardrails to keep development work Complex instead of Chaotic.
- 7.2 Evaluate Technical Debt as deficiencies the Team will have to pay later.
- 7.3 Design a Standard of Care that keeps a Team from creating its own Chaos.
- 7.4 Recommend capability-building when the Team is not self-contained.
- 7.5 Judge whether Acts of God are being used to hide Guardrail failures.

MODULE 08

From Idea to Strategy to Product

- 8.1 Trace work from Idea through Strategy and Vision into Product.
- 8.2 Evaluate a Product Vision against Moore's template as a draft, not a freeze.
- 8.3 Design a Story Map that turns strategy into an Initial Backlog and a Release Plan.
- 8.4 Judge how fast Vision, Backlog, and Product should be allowed to change.
- 8.5 Recommend how Product Ownership facets get instantiated across an Organization.

MODULE 09

Starting a New Scrum Team

- 9.1 Use Scrum's Circle of Life to see what a new Team must put in place.
- 9.2 Balance the Production Game and the Improvement Game from the first Sprint.
- 9.3 Instantiate Product Ownership facets so a new Team is not Product-Owner-optional.
- 9.4 Evaluate whether a new Team has Guardrails before it has forecasts.

MODULE 10

Adopting Scrum

- 10.1 Evaluate an Organization against the Extended Agile Manifesto.
- 10.2 Use the three Guardrails as the adoption test, not ceremony compliance.
- 10.3 Map a current value stream before changing the process.
- 10.4 Run Five Whys or a Causal Factor chart on an Organizational impediment.
- 10.5 Recommend whether the next move is Team change or Organization change.
- 10.6 Design an adoption step that attacks waste without installing empty Scrum forms.

MODULE 11

Scaling (Part 1)

- 11.1 Evaluate Scaling as an Organization's response to increasing demand.
- 11.2 Trace Sam's shop through hiring, Product Ownership, splitting, and centralizing.
- 11.3 Judge when absorbing another Organization creates coupling the Teams cannot carry.
- 11.4 Recommend when shared Best Practices help and when they become a tax.
- 11.5 Evaluate economies of scale against the cost of distance from the Client.

MODULE 12

Scaling (Part 2)

- 12.1 Design a single-layer Pod with a Flow Management Team and Production Teams.
- 12.2 Evaluate the Production Train as the path work takes through the Pod.
- 12.3 Distinguish the Scrum Master Team from the Scrum-of-Scrums.
- 12.4 Design a Cross-Cutting Workgroup without stealing people from existing Teams.
- 12.5 Recommend when a Pod should grow versus when a new Pod should start.
- 12.6 Assess remote TeamLets inside a Pod without pretending colocation is required.

MODULE 13

Leadership

- 13.1 Evaluate Product Owners as Team Captains who combine Manager and Director work.
- 13.2 Diagnose how a would-be Perfect Team Captain becomes a Bad Boss.
- 13.3 Select Autocratic, Participative, or Delegative style to match the decision.
- 13.4 Use Emergent Leadership instead of forcing every lead through the Team Captain.
- 13.5 Design a path for a Team Captain that keeps accountability and does not blame the Team.

3Back delivers Scrum Mastering III. RSM3 is recognized by the Scrum Guide Organization. These objectives follow Scrum Mastering III: Organizational Improvement by Dan Rawsthorne and Doug Shimp.